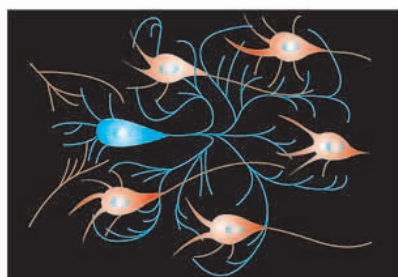


Teenage brain

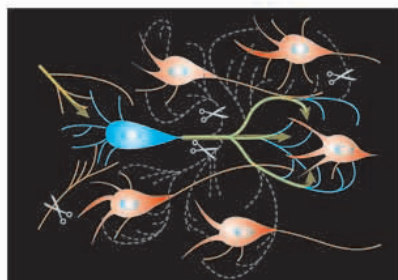
During the teenage years, the brain goes through dramatic changes. Circuits that aren't needed are pruned away, while others strengthen and mature. This period of change affects how you feel and behave, causing mood swings, risky behavior, and sometimes physical and social clumsiness.

USE IT OR LOSE IT

In early life, millions of connections form between brain cells, making your brain quick to learn. During the teenage years, however, circuits that haven't been used are pruned away, making your brain faster but less adaptable.



▲ **EARLY CHILDHOOD**
Connections form between brain cells, creating millions of potential circuits.



▲ **TEENAGE YEARS**
Unused connections are pruned away, while others become stronger.

WOW!

Learning skills such as skiing or surfing becomes harder after you reach the teenage years because your brain becomes less flexible.

INSIDE THE TEENAGE BRAIN

The human brain keeps on changing and developing well into our twenties. Changes happen in many parts of the brain, including the gray matter on the surface and deeper structures in the heart of the brain. The maturing process starts at the back and works forward, with the frontal lobes—the areas responsible for thinking and problem solving—maturing last.

The corpus callosum is a bundle of nerves joining the left and right sides of the brain. It thickens during our teens.

In charge of planning and decision-making, the frontal lobes enable us to think ahead before acting rashly. They are the last parts of the brain to mature.

SLOW RISER

Teenagers find it much harder than adults to get up in the morning. The teenage brain not only needs about two hours more sleep, but also has a different cycle of daily activity, being most active late in the day and sluggish in the mornings.

